

Activity 2 – The Art of the Prompt

From Vague Requests to Designed Prompts

Purpose

Move from typing vague requests into AI tools to **designing clear, structured prompts** that produce more relevant, useful outputs for your context.

Core Activity (Teaching / Pedagogy)

Step 1 – Choose a real prompt you used

Take one prompt you actually used earlier in the workshop (for example, in Activity 1) – even if it was messy or vague.

Write it in the space below:

Original prompt:

Step 2 – Apply a simple prompt structure

Rewrite your prompt using this pattern:

- **CONTEXT** – Who you are, what you teach, level, constraints
- **ROLE** – Who you want the AI to pretend to be
- **ACTION** – What you want it to do
- **FORMAT** – How you want the answer structured
- **TONE / CONSTRAINTS** – Style, length, level

Example (teaching idea):

You are an experienced **[discipline]** educator.

I teach a **[year level]** unit on **[topic]** with about **[class size]** students.

Suggest **3 in-class activities (15–20 minutes each)** to help students apply the concept of **[concept]** to real-world examples.

For each activity, provide:

- A brief description
- Materials needed
- Clear instructions I can read out loud
- One debrief question to link back to theory

Now rewrite your own prompt using this style:

Improved prompt (CONTEXT + ROLE + ACTION + FORMAT + TONE):

Step 3 – Compare outputs

Run both prompts (original and improved) in your AI tool.

Compare:

- Which output is **clearer and more relevant** to your context?
- Which one would save you **more time** in preparing teaching materials?
- What changed in the prompt that made the difference?

Step 4 – Optional: Use AI to help refine your prompt

If you like, you can ask the AI to be a “prompt coach”:

Here is my prompt:

[paste your improved prompt]

Suggest **3 ways to make this prompt clearer and more specific** for my goal. Then show me a revised version.

Decide whether any of the suggested changes actually help, and adjust your prompt accordingly.

Extra Prompt Patterns (Teaching / Pedagogy)

You can adapt these patterns to your own unit.

A. Feedback helper with guardrails

You are an experienced university lecturer.

CONTEXT: I teach [**discipline**], [**year level**]. This is **formative feedback**, not a final grade.

ACTION: Help me draft feedback on the following student work:

[paste short excerpt]

CONSTRAINTS:

- Start with one positive comment.
- Then give 2–3 specific, actionable suggestions.
- Do not assign a mark or grade.
- Use supportive, professional language.

B. Redesigning an activity

You are a learning designer.

CONTEXT: I teach [**unit / year level / discipline**] with about [**class size**] students.

CURRENT ACTIVITY: [briefly describe what you currently do]

ACTION: Suggest **2 alternative activity designs** that:

- Use AI as a support tool, not a replacement for student thinking
- Make students' reasoning more visible (e.g., asking them to annotate or explain AI outputs)
- Can be run in a **30-minute tutorial**

FORMAT: Return your answer as a table with columns: "Activity Name", "What Students Do", "How AI is Used", "How I Assess or Observe Learning".

Variants for Researchers and Professional Staff

You can use the same prompt makeover pattern for non-teaching work.

If you are mainly doing research

Try a prompt makeover for:

- **Literature reviews**
 - Vague: "Help me with my literature review."
 - Structured:
 - > You are a research assistant in [**field**].
 - > I am working on a project about [**topic**] at [**stage: early/late**].
 - > Using the following list of papers / abstracts, group them into **3–5 themes** and suggest **one gap** in the literature for each theme.
 - > FORMAT: table with columns: "Theme", "Key papers", "Possible gap".
- **Grant or ethics documents**

- Ask for structured prompts to draft or improve: impact sections, lay summaries, interview protocols.

If you are in a professional / administrative role

Try a prompt makeover for:

- **Student communications**

- Vague: “Write an email about enrolment.”
- Structured:
 - > You are a student communications officer at an Australian university.
 - > CONTEXT: This email is for [cohort / year] students about [issue].
 - > ACTION: Draft a clear, concise email explaining what students need to do and by when.
 - > FORMAT: 3 short paragraphs + a bullet list of actions.
 - > TONE: friendly, professional, and non-threatening.

- **Web copy or FAQs**

- Provide CONTEXT, ROLE, ACTION, FORMAT and TONE so the AI writes in a way that fits your audience and channel.

Reflection / Notes

Use the prompts below and the space provided.

- What changed in your improved prompt that made the output better?
- Which parts of the CONTEXT / ROLE / ACTION / FORMAT / TONE structure do you find most useful?
- Where could a “prompt makeover” help you in your unit, project, or role?

(Notes:)

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